chance to score some runs in the series would've been the worst thing I could've done. As it turned out, it wasn't.

The night before the game, we had a team dinner at Vilamoura restaurant at the Sandton Sun Hotel in Joburg, where we were staying. I had a big piece of steak for dinner and drank some wine. Quite a lot of wine. I wasn't too concerned about getting a little tipsy in front of my teammates and the team management. As I've said, people can seldom tell when I'm drunk, unless – obviously – I'm properly slaughtered. Or maybe I should say: I don't think people notice when I'm drunk, but I can't really tell when I'm the one who's pissed, can I? I guess people I know – for example, my teammates – can see I'm acting differently, but I never notice it. So that evening, I kept on drinking. And I had another steak.

The team all went to bed, but I stayed at the restaurant. Although an actual curfew did not exist, you were, of course, expected to get some decent sleep the night before a game. Anyway, a mate of mine came round and I carried on drinking – I probably only got to bed at about 1 a.m. By rights I should've been in shocking nick the next day, but I ended up scoring 102 off 84, during which I klapped 13 fours and three sixes.

Just as he did after the 438 game, coach Mickey Arthur came up to me and said, 'Hersch, I do not fucking know how you fucking do it.' He was half annoyed, half pleased: never a comfortable mix. 'I was about to give you the lecture you deserve, but how can I when you get 100 off 80-odd balls?'

It became a running joke after that game. The guys would egg me on to drink lots of wine and to eat two steaks before every game so that I would get a big score.

Perhaps the alcohol had relaxed me, allowing me to just go out and play my natural game. Or perhaps I just operate better on very little sleep.

When we were touring Zimbabwe in September 2001, I had a raging argument with a girl I was seeing at the time, and I probably didn't get more than a couple of hours of sleep that night. I was rooming with Claude Henderson on that tour, and I don't think he got too much sleep either. Anyway, I scored 147 the next day. It was the first Test and Gary and I put on an opening stand of 256, with Gary eventually out on 220. Jacques Kallis added to the Zim misery by also scoring 157 not out. I have an inborn energy that allows me to not only function on little sleep, but function really well.